

The Three Princes of Serendipity

—“So, children, are you ready for another story of the Captain?”

Aw, her favorite are the Princess and her Knight, but the boys like the Captain. Well, whatever story Varaz is going to tell them, it is always great fun. She pulls Āzar a little closer to her on their cushion—in case it got scary. The new girl is sitting at the back, so she waves to her to come sit with them too.

—“Abrangih, come. It’s gonna be so good!”

He waits for the new girl to sit with Borān and Āzar, on their cushion right in front of him.

—“Alright then, children, let’s get to today’s story:”

One day, the Captain decides to set sail to the southern lands whose fame he has heard of. He is going there because he hopes to find his friends, the Princess and her Knight. Remember how they saved his life from the lion? But he never got to thank them, and so, he thinks, the Princess and the Knight, perhaps they went to this fabled land, far in the south, past the shores of India. It’s called Sarandipa, for it is the mythical land of the lions. 🦁

—“You’re making that up, Varaz!”

He never can figure out why Shirowe always wants to be there, to listen to his stories, while, at the same time, constantly trying to debunk them. Luckily, his savior is also in the room, in the shape of Her Majesty the *Bāmbishn* [Queen], the sister of the *Shāhān-Shāh* [King of Kings].

—“Derived from *Simhala-dvipa* [Sri Lanka], meaning in the ancient tongue island of the lion.”

Auntie makes that stupid Shirowe shut up. Ooh, baby Shasha woke up!

—“Borān, sit down,” Āzar pulls her back down, “Varaz is gonna tell the story.”

Her sister is right. She’ll go ask later whether she can hold the baby.

So, thus, as it seems, from one lion to the other, hither the Captain went, in search of the Princess and her valiant Knight. Sailing night and day. And then one day, what is it that he sees? There! Are that people waving on the shore? 🦁

—“The Princess and her Knight! Yay!”

BUt wait! It's three people. Who else is there? And so, he tells his sailors to get a little closer. And when they come closer, they can see that three young men are waving at them. And they are calling out in despair:

~"O dear Captain, please save use. Bandits have captured us, but we managed to escape, and now we are alone here and we fear they may come back and catch us." What should he do? Help them? But what if it is a ruse? Pirates are known to pretend to be some lost soul and then they board your ship and then... 🐼

Varaz's gesture makes them all gasp. Pirates are scary!

SO, the captain thinks to himself ~"What if these are truly poor souls in need of assistance, but I just sail by and leave them to their sorry lot. How can I face the Princess and her valiant Knight ever again! No, it is the code of the sea that we must help our fellow seamen in distress! I know what to do!" And so, he commands his sailors to lower one of the rowing boats into the water.

~"I will go check it out myself. If they are pirates, I will signal you and you sail away as fast as you can! And if they are friendly, I will be back with them." And thus he rows to the the three waving men. But then, when he gets out of the water—oh, dear—, they all of a sudden leap towards him and they ... hug him and thank him, for they are honorable men. Thieves have taken their horses and their bags and their robes. And so they are standing there, with only a shirt and their pants. The Captain looks at them. He can tell they are brothers, but they each have one distinctive feature.

The first one is as tall as a tree. But his brother, the second one, he has eyes as blue-green as the sky. And the third brother, he has a mustache as large as a bush. The Captain asks who they are and they say that their father is the King of Sarandipa—remember the island the Captain was going to—what about that? Is that not a lucky coincidence. They are the three Princes of Sarandipa, whom their father endowed not only with great power, but also with all kinds

of virtues of which princes are particularly in need.¹ The tall one says,

~“I am the first-born son, and my father made me prince of the eastern kingdom.” And the one with the blue-green eyes, he is the second prince, and his father has given him the western part to rule, and the one with the big mustache, he is the youngest and he is the prince of the Middle Realm. And they tell the Captain how their father has sent them to India, to find out what its greatest treasure is. And on their voyage, one day, a *brahmanag*—that is what they call their *mowbed* [priests] there: *brahmanag*. And when the three Princes of Sarandipa ask the pious man, what is the greatest treasure in these lands, he replies

~“Why do you want to know?”

~“So that we can purchase it as a gift for our father. Look, we brought many *drahm*.” And they show it to the holy man, who looks at it with admiration, for the land of Sarandipa is very rich.

~“Well, noble princes, there is this castle, not far from here, in which live three beautiful princesses. It is a marvelous site, twenty stories high, built with bricks in all sorts of color and its dome is made from alabaster, so that it shines like the sun during the day and glows like the moon at night.” And then the *brahmanag* tells the three princes the name of this magical castle: Gamdan. . . ❧

Abrangih, next to her, lets out a loud gasp.

—“Abrangih, what is it?”

She whispers.

—“I was born in that castle!”

She whispers back.

—“Abrangih, how is that possible!”

—“I tell you, Borān, it’s true. By MEHR!”

Alright, that needs some clarification.

—“Varaz, our friend Abrangih says that she was born in that castle,” they now all look surprised at the girl, “Is that true?”

Āzar looks at her with big eyes.

¹Christophe the Armenian, prologue.

—“Oh, Abrangih, are you ... are you one of the three princesses?”

The girl looks helplessly from the *Bāmbishn* to him. *Pargast*, how is it possible that someone would know about this castle in far Yemen that he had intended to use in his story? Let alone have been born there!? Could she really be from that place? He has to find out later. Seeing her desperate look, he comes to her rescue.

—“Ha, ha, wouldn’t that be something! But no, you’re right, I got my castles mixed up, ha, ha. But coming back to our story...”

THE *brahmanag* tells the three princes that there, in the castle that shall remain nameless, ha, ha, live three sisters, of a beauty the world has never seen before.

~“So, dear *Sri* [Lords], that is the greatest treasure of our land. And their father will gladly accept your coin. Hurry, *Sri*, for many suitors will come ask for the hand of those magnificent pearls.” And so, very excited, the three Princes of Sarandipa embark in search of the mysterious castle with its ravishing residents. ♣

—“But, children, you’re not going to believe this...”

He shakes his head, making them all look at him with big eyes.

—“What? What?”

—“That *brahmanag*, well, not so holy after all, for he covets their *drahm*.”

—“So, he is like our *mowbed*!”

They all laugh, although a little uncomfortably, with Shirowe’s joke.

SO, when the princes finally get to the place, it turns out to be a little hillock with a boulder on top—see, there was no castle and therefore it had no name, ha, ha. And instead of the three most beautiful princesses in the land, a bunch of ugly bandits jump from behind the boulder and they take all the *drahm* of the three Princes and strip them down to their shirts. And so, the three Princes, they run and run until they reach the shore and they see a ship and that’s when they wave to the Captain. And now, the Captain feels sorry for them and promises them to take them back to their father’s land and he rows them back to their boat. And when they lift them up onto the deck, he greets them with a resounding: ~“Welcome aboard!”

But, children, that is not yet the end of the story. That is not yet the end of Princes' misfortunes. For then this happened. That evil *brahmanag*, he had bragged to his friend about how he was going to dupe the three Princes and now he was going to get rich. But his friend thinks, why should I not be the one to take all their coin and get rich. And he goes to his two brothers, who are pirates like him, and he tells them of the three rich Princes.

~"If we are quick, we can beat the *brahmanag*'s men and get the Princes' riches for ourselves." And so, they go to the sea-side. And they see an old man cleaning out his fishing nets. So, they ask

~"Father dear, have you seen three Princes coming this way?" And he nods and tells them that he has seen just a while ago three young men climb onto the Captain's ship, and he points to a little dot on the horizon. So, not knowing that the three Princes already have been robbed, they sail after them. And in the night—it's so dark, you cannot even see your own nose. 🐷

They all giggle as Varaz pretends to not find his nose.

They row with a little boat next to the Captain's ship and they climb on board, just when the sun rises in the east. And only then do the Captain's men notice the intruders. But it is too late, children! They point their swords at the Captain's throat.

~"You'd better tell us the truth!" He nods, for he knows that you have to be very careful with pirates or they chop off your head! *Āy wāy*, this could end very badly, children!

~"What do you want from me?"

~"Did you give passage to three young men?"

~"I sail to far places and give passage in exchange for coin whomever asks me."

~"And among your passengers, are there not three Princes from Sarandipa?" The Captain shrugs his shoulders.

~"How would I know which three young men you are talking about? Tell me how they look like." And the first pirate, he tries to remember their description from his friend the

brahmanag.

~“Well, the first one, he has eyes as blue-green as the sea.”

~“The first you say, blue-green as the sea? Hmm, the *first one*, no, that’s not him.” 🍷

They start chuckling, as they can tell how it is going to go. And if that was not clear yet, Āzar shouts out

—“The Captain is not lying, right Varaz, because the first one is the tall one,” and then she proudly adds, “For you cannot say a lie, ever!”

—“Except when you tell mother Shirin that you didn’t go outside, but I saw you play in the courtyard!”

She looks furiously at Shirowe, but realizing she has no rebuttal, she turns instead to him. So, he quickly continues.

—“Āzar is right, he will not tell a lie.”

THe pirate gets a little annoyed.

~“The second prince, he has a mustache as large as a bush.” The Captain goes

~“The second one, you say, hmm, . . . a large mustache? No, not that I recall.”

~“But surely, you remember the third one, for he is as tall as that mast there!”

~“The third one, tall? Like that wooden beam? Nope, that’s not him.” But the pirates are not convinced, and so, the first one insists.

~“Where are your passengers now?”

~“Below deck, resting in their quarters.”

~“I want to see for myself!”

~“By all means!” And he points to a hatch and some stairs that lead down below deck. And so, the first pirate goes down the stairs, but after a while, he pops his head up and says

~“It’s too dark down there, I cannot see anything.” And the Captain lights a torch and gives it to the second pirate.

~“Here, help your brother see.” But after a while, the brother now pops up and says.

~“The door is locked!”

~“Oh, right, sorry, I forgot,” and he gives the key to the third pirate, “Here, your brothers need the key.” And the third pi-

rate goes down with the key. But as soon as he is down, the Captain closes the hatch behind them, and the pirates are captured! 🐉

—“Huzzah!”

—“But, Varaz, what is the Captain going to do with those pirates?”

—“You guys wanna know?”

Āzar now chimes in.

—“Yeah, Varaz. And also, those poor Princes? They lost everything, Varaz! The Captain has to help them!”

As usual, the children want the story to end happily. Well, that’s what he is here for, ha, ha.

—“But it is getting late. . . , perhaps we should wait until next time. . . .”

That will of course just fuel them even more on.

—“No, Varaz!! Tell us now!”

—“Alright then. Let justice be done!”

SO, the Captain decides to take his prisoners to the King of Sind, *Raj Sahasi*, and he sets sail to the great port of Deval. 🐉

—“Deval?”

—“Yeah, some say its name means Port of the Devs (demons) but others say its name is City of the Divine.”

How can one city be both of the gods and of the demons? Varaz always comes up with these silly names. She glances at her brother lurking at the door post. For sure that annoying Shirowe is going to make fun of Varaz!

—“Varaz, is it safe to go there?”

—“Yes, Borān, don’t worry. The King of Sind is a benevolent and fair ruler. And he will see to it that justice is done.”

AND so, the Captain, in the company of the three Princes, brings those vile pirates to *Raj Sahasi* at his court. And the King forthwith throws those wicked buccaneers in the dungeon.

~“Well, esteemed Captain, once more have you rid the seas of this scourge. But alas, as many as I have in my dungeons, still more are filling our waters and threatening the good merchants of Sind and Persia.”

~“May MEHR smite their heads!” The Queen of Sind, the

lovely Suhandi, now turns to our three youngsters.

~“And who are these three handsome young men you brought with you, Captain?”

~“Oh, the pirates wanted to capture them, for they had heard of their great wealth. For they are princes of a far kingdom. But alas, other robbers already had taken everything they possessed and now they have but the clothes on their back.”

~“O dear husband, we have to help these poor souls.”

~“You’re right, Suhandi my love, what unfathomable injustice has been done to such noble men! We shall see to it that they are properly dressed and returned safely to their own country.” And so, the three Princes thank the King abundantly. But the Captain can tell that something is still bothering *Raj Sahasi*.

~“Your Majesty, you seem troubled.”

~“I am, dear Captain, for just this morning I received several letters threatening to attack my kingdom unless I pay a hefty ransom.”

~“Who sent these letters to you, Your Majesty.”

~“Here, see for yourself.” And so, he shows three letters to the Captain. But as he does, the eldest Prince exclaims in surprise

~“It bears the seal of the Eastern Realm of Sarandipa!” And then the one with the blue-green eyes is surprised to see that the second letter bears the seal of the Western Realm. And then the youngest, . . . , yep, it’s the seal of the Middle Realm. And so the three Princes exclaim

~“These are our seals!”

~“What?? You are the Three Princes of Sarandipa?!” the King is horrified and immediately orders his guards to put the three Princes in chains, “You wicked men, you are worse than those pirates that wanted to capture you. I should free them and deliver you in their custody, so that they can exact their revenge on you!”

~“But, Your Majesty, we did not write those letters!”

~“So, you did not threaten us, with your fancy words, that ‘innocent heads will be slivered if due tribute is not delivered: you shall purvey without delay, tenthousand vats of

musk, augment without argument, with tenthousand vats of spikenard, and finally, concluding the contract by transacting the transfer of tenthousand vats of castor oil! Lest calamity will befall you, docility shall become you!’ By your own admittance, these are your seals!” And he shows the Captain the letter in which it says just that. Children, they were going to extort the King of Sind! 🌱

Could it be that those three Princes are not as nice as they thought? She glances at her sister, who looks equally conflicted.

—“They didn’t do it, right, Varaz?”

—“Who will tell, Āzar, who will tell?”

BUt naturally, the Princes protest and demand to be heard. So, the King orders his chamberlain—his name is Ram—to come to the throne room and interrogate the three youngsters. But when chamberlain Ram enters, the three Princes let out a loud scream! How is that possible!? 🌱

—“Children, you’re not going to believe this...”

—“What, Varaz, what?”

—“Ram, the chamberlain, it is ... the *brahmanag* who had tricked them.”

That causes a big ooh among his young audience. And even the *Bāmbishn* looks a little puzzled. Yeah, straight from a narrator’s box of tricks: implausible adventitiousness—that probably was not even a word, but you got the picture, ha, ha. Of course, Shirowe has to call him out for it.

—“Pff, impossible!!”

—“Aha, it seems you guys don’t believe it!”

WEll, neither does the King.

~“How dare you to accuse my loyal chamberlain!” In despair, the three Princes turn to the Captain.

~“Captain, you have to believe us. That man there, he was the one who told us about the castle, but it was just a desolate rock where his men were waiting for us!” The chamberlain, of course, denies everything.

~“I am a *brahmanag*, a man of god, upholder of That Which is One Without a Second. That is how I am!² I would never do such things you accuse me of. My liege, we should throw

²Chandogya Upanishad, 6.2.1, 6.8.7.

them in our deepest dungeon for these men are not only extortionists, but slanderers to boot." The Captain though doesn't trust chamberlain Ram. There is something he noticed. Could it possibly help exonerate his three trembling companions? ♣

—"What did he see, Varaz?"

—"The way they went to sleep!"

—"Huh? How can that possibly help them?!"

—"Aha, a skeptical audience. A demonstration is in order then! Children, let's pretend we're going to sleep. We're getting tired and then what do we do?"

—"We yawn?!"

—"Exactly. Let's all do that. But, let's be polite and cover it up with our hand," they all start yawning. It makes you actually feel sleepy, but luckily Varaz goes on, "now, children, I want you to tell me, with which hand did you cover your mouth."

She sticks up her hand.

—"This one, my right hand."

The others all say the same, except for Abrangih.

—"I used my left, Varaz."

—"That is because left is right for you, *doshag* [dear]!"

—"Huh?"

—"Well, children, tell me, with which hand do you write?"

They all shout

—"The right!"

Except again Abrangih, who says left. Wow, who knew? You yawn with the same hand you write?

—"See, children, while most of us are right-handed, some are not. And so, from going to sleep, you can tell who is what! Like the Princes, who, the Captain had noticed, always yawn with their right hand."

—"But how is that going to help them now, Varaz?"

—"Aha, that's where the writing comes in. See, those who are right-handed, slant left in their writing."

—"That doesn't sound right."

—"Because it's left, ha, ha. Since you push your quill to the write as you right, I mean, to the right as you write, with your right hand, the letters all come out tilting to the left."

—“You’re making that up, Varaz!”

—“I did not! Upon this salt I swear,” he foresaw this objection and so he brought a little satchel with salt, “See, we Armenians, we always swear on salt. But if you do not believe me, let’s try it out.”

He spreads the satchel on the floor.

—“What are you doing, Varaz?”

—“A test! Abrangih, Āzar, come here, and write your names in the salt with your finger, please.”

In her enthusiasm, Āzar accidentally disturbs Abrangih’s writing so, after some giggling, they have to do it again.

—“Now, Shirowe, we need your discerning eye. Tell me which one is what? The first letter, it’s supposed to be the same, right? Or left?”

Shirowe has to admit that they slant differently. How cool is that!

—“And what about the Princes, Varaz?”

—“Well, the Captain noticed that the three ransom letters all were written in beautiful calligraphy, slanting to the right. Now, we just established that this means that its author is left-handed.”

—“Oh, I see, Varaz, it’s not the Princes who wrote the letter! They yawn with their right hand!”

—“Indeed, Āzar. Unfortunately, I just don’t think that it is going to be enough to convince *Raj Sahasi*. The Captain needs a better argument.”

Luckily, the Captain has a plan!

~“Your Majesty, you know that I always am on the side of justice. And to let justice prevail, perhaps we can do a little experiment.”

~“Experiment?”

~“To find out who is liar and who tells the truth.”

~“And how would you do this, dear Captain?”

~“Give each of these three Princes a parchment and a quill to write, and also one to your chamberlain. And let them write down in their own words, whether they did it or not.”

~“If you think this will work.” And so the King commands the four men to write down their intentions. 🐼

—“Oh, I figured it out, Varaz! From the way it tilts, like left or right, they can tell, right?”

—“Alas, Āzar, as I already said, graphology is never going to convince the king. No, not format but content will reveal the true culprit.”

—“Content? That is just dumb! Of course, they all are going to say they didn’t.”

—“You’re right, Shirowe, that they will do. But what matters is the manner in which they do.”

—“Huh?”

See, children, the Captain had noticed something else. While traveling with his companions, he learned that these three Princes are kind, and brave, and noble, and handsome too—I’ll grant you that—but... let’s say, they are ... a few eggs short of a dozen.

And so, the eldest Prince, he writes ‘I not do it’. And the second one writes ‘I not do’, and the youngest, he just says ‘I not’. And then the Captain reads out aloud the letter of the Chamberlain Ram: ‘My innocence is as irreproachable as the magnificence of the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky.’

~“Tell me, Your Majesty, does your Chamberlain not always say ‘eloquence is the origin of good fortune and the solver of difficulties.’³ So, which of those men writing these letters is showing you his eloquence ready to claim justice?”

~“Well, my Chamberlain, of course, a most learned man, an adept at our ancient texts.”

~“And these three Princes, would you say they are too?”

~“Hmm, no, not really.”

~“But those three letters you showed me, when they demand this ransom of Your Majesty. Wouldn’t you say that they’re well-crafted and articulate?”

~“Hmm, now that you mention it, they do sound a little like.... *Pargast* [Damn], it is him!” The Queen now gets it too.

~“Husband, Ram has deceived you! You must cast him out. Call instead for young Chāch, his secretary. He is a pious man and will never deceive you!” And thus the King decrees

~“Chāch, as your master has betrayed us, henceforth, you will serve as my loyal councilor.”

~“If it pleases my King,” and then he bows reverently before

³Chachname, §2.

the queen, “and my Queen.”

~“Now, search your master’s quarters and find the treasure he took from these three honorable men.” And that’s, children, how the Captain exposes that traitorous chamberlain! See, when he had robbed the three Princes of their money and belongings, wicked Ram also had grabbed their signet rings and with it he had written these letters to *Raj Sahasi*, extorting him so that he could become the wealthiest man in the whole of Sind. And then, *āy wāy*, he was going to take the King’s wife, lovely Suhandi, as his! But Chāch found the *drahm* Ram had hidden and returned them to the three Princes, who were overjoyed to not have lost the treasure of Sarandipa. ❧

—“Yay! And now queen Suhandi’s honor is safe, right?”

—“Yes, Āzar, her honor is safe.”

A light chuckle is coming from his left. It’s the *Bāmbishn*. What is that about? But he still has one more twist to . . . , well, twist.

BUt something still puzzles Queen Suhandi.

~“Good *Sri*, why did you let that vile Ram convince you to go to that castle?”

~“He told us, Your Majesty, that three princesses are awaiting us there and that their father would happily have us pay their dower and make them our brides.” Queen Suhandi starts laughing. ❧

While he imitates the laughing queen, Āzar gets annoyed.

—“Why is she laughing, Varaz? What’s so funny? It’s not their fault that that evil Ram tricked them.”

SHe does not laugh with them, but with this most fortuitous coincidence.

~“As fate would have it, our three daughters require noble grooms. For so long have we been searching for suitable suitors, but none were ever worthy for our three pearls,” she turns to the King, “Husband, as a gift from heaven, these three Princes have come from distant Sarandipa, making our prayers come true.”

~“What happy coincidence indeed. I assumed, being such

handsome men, you already had been bequeathed by your father. But here you stand, three lovely bachelors. Chāch, go fetch my daughters! They will be so happy!” And so, three lovely princesses enter the room. Wow, the three Princes are immediately enamored! The tall Prince, he fancies the first princess, for she is as tall as him. And the Prince with blue-green eyes, he is smitten with the second princess for her eyes are as blue-green as his. And then the Prince with the big mustache, he really likes the third princess, for she has... 🌹

He waits deliberately, until some of the boys start to snigger, figuring out what he is getting at. After a while, the girls get it too, and look at him with pleading eyes—yeah, princesses are not supposed to be hairy, at least not there, ha, ha.

SHe has the longest and blackest hair, all the way to her hips. And the third Prince, well, he can’t get her eyes off of her. So, the three Princes exclaim

~“*Raj Sahasi*, tell us your price and we will gladly pay their dowry.”

~“Well, dear daughters, what shall I ask your grooms?” And the first one says.

~“Noble Prince, just give me a rose and I will be yours forever.” And so the first Prince gives his beloved a beautiful red rose and their love blossoms in front of every one’s eyes. And then the second one says

~“Just give me a holy book and beside you I will pray for the duration of my life.” And the second Prince fetches a silver bible and before the King and Queen, they vow to be each other’s forever. And then the third princess coyly asks

~“Noble Prince, just give me kiss.” And so he does, and... 🌹

The obligatory pause. As usual, little Āzar caves first.

—“Varaz, what? And what?”

—“It... tickles.”

They all burst out in laughter. Varaz is so funny, ha, ha, ha. And the end is so nice, all the princes and princesses get married. Yay! Her brother, of course, has to scorn Varaz again.

—“What an unlikely story! One coincidence after the other. That’s not

possible!"

—"And yet it happened, Shirowe!"

As always with their final discussion, they both look at the *Bāmbishn* for approval.

—"Come on, aunt, tell them, what is the likelihood of all of this?"

—"Negligible," his detractor looks triumphantly at him, "Yet, five years ago, Warden Shahrwarāz effectuated the incarceration of King Sahasi's chamberlain Ram for aiding and abetting pirates and ratified the appointment of vizier Chāch."

What *pad Yazdān* [by the gods] for a coincidence was that! That was one a la Sarandipa, ha, ha! And to add to his astonishment, after the children ran to the dining room, the *Bāmbishn* continues

—"Warden Shahrwarāz," that's actually her husband, Shasha's daddy, but she never refers to him like that—funny thing, his name, Shahrwarāz, also means boar, like his own, "also suspects amorous relations between vizier Chāch and queen Suhandi—an illicit romance ill-suited for children's tales."

—"I... I had no clue, *spās* [thanks], Your Majesty."

She turns around, while speaking in her usual, monotone voice.

—"Paddrod [bye], Varaz."

—"Paddrod, Your Majesty. See you next time!"